

Less TTT, More STT

Guide to Maximizing Student Speaking Time and Reducing Teacher Talk Time

ELING 375

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Maximizing Student Talk Time (STT)

Reduce	Increase
Long explanations	Visual scaffolds and modeling
Teacher-led questioning	Pair and group interaction
Display questions	Referential questions
Immediate correction	Delayed feedback
Whole-class recitation	Simultaneous speaking tasks
Teacher-managed turns	Student-to-student exchanges

Seven Research-Supported Principles

Principle 1: Design tasks that require communication.

Principle 2: Maximize pair and small-group interaction.

Principle 3: Ask authentic questions with multiple possible answers.

Principle 4: Use concise instructions supported by visuals, routines, or models.

Principle 5: Allow adequate wait time before intervening.

Principle 6: Focus on meaning during communication tasks.

Principle 7: Provide most corrective feedback after the task.

Sample High-Impact Activities

Activity	Purpose
Information Gap	Partners hold different information and must communicate to complete a task.
Describe and Draw	One student describes; the other draws.
Picture Differences	Students identify differences without sharing images.
Opinion Line	Students justify positions along an agree-disagree continuum.
Running Dictation	Movement, memory, listening, and speaking combined.
Story Skeletons	Students build connected narratives from prompts.

Proficiency-Level Implementation Guide

Level	ACTFL	Focus	Recommended Tasks	Example Output
Pre-A1–A1	Novice Low/Novice Mid–Novice High	Words and chunks	Color information gaps; TPR Plus; Describe & Draw	'Red.' 'Blue circle.'
A2	Novice High–Intermediate Low	Short sentences	Spot the Difference; Opinion Lines; Classroom Mixers	'I agree because...'
B1	Intermediate Mid–Intermediate High	Connected sentences	Process descriptions; Story Skeletons	'First... Next... After that...'
B2–C1	Advanced Low–Advanced Mid–Advanced High–Superior	Extended discourse	Problem-solving; Academic discussions; Fishbowls	Reasoned explanations and negotiation

Lesson Planning Checklist

- ☐ Students have a genuine reason to communicate.
- ☐ The task requires information exchange or negotiation of meaning.
- ☐ Instructions are supported by visuals, examples, or models.
- ☐ Students will spend more time speaking than I will.
- ☐ Most questions are referential rather than display-oriented.

Questions where the speaker **does not already know the answer** and is seeking genuine information, opinions, or personal experiences

- ☐ Students can interact with peers without relying on the teacher.
- ☐ Most feedback will be delayed until after the task.
- ☐ Pair or group work allows simultaneous participation.
- ☐ Expected language support (frames, word banks, visuals) is available.
- ☐ I have planned how to monitor rather than dominate interaction.

Visual Reminders

1. TRANSFORM THE INTERACTION ENGINE

From Teacher-Centered to Student-Centered Talk

THE OLD WAY: IRF/IRE PATTERN

One student speaks at a time.

❌ Limits interaction, creates bottlenecks, and reduces student talking time.

THE BETTER WAY: STUDENT ↔ STUDENT

Students take more turns and build on each other's ideas.

✅ More student talk, richer interaction, and authentic communication.

💡 Goal: Increase the quantity and quality of Student Talk Time (STT).

2. USE STRATEGIC WAIT TIME

Silence is not empty. It is thinking in progress.

INSTEAD OF...

Jumping in too quickly or answering your own question.

❌

TRY THIS...

Wait 3-5 seconds to give students processing time.

✅

⭐ More wait time = longer, more complete student responses.

3. ENGINEER INFORMATION GAPS & MAXIMIZE SIMULTANEOUS SPEAKING

Real communication happens when students need each other.

INFORMATION GAPS

Give students different pieces of information so they have a reason to talk. →

Partner A has this...

Weekend Plans	
Where	?
With Whom	Friends
Activity	?
Time	Saturday

Partner B has this...

Weekend Plans	
Where	The beach
With Whom	?
Activity	Swimming
Time	?

They must ask, answer, and share to complete the task.

✅ Information gaps create a genuine need to communicate.

SPEAKING OPPORTUNITIES: WHOLE CLASS vs. PAIR/SMALL GROUPS

More simultaneous speakers = more Student Talk Time (STT).

WHOLE CLASS (Teacher Questioning)

Only one student speaks at a time.

~3% of class time speaking

PAIR / SMALL GROUPS

Many students speak at the same time.

50-100% of class time speaking

✅ Design tasks that allow multiple conversations to happen at once.

🏆 **THE BOTTOM LINE:** Effective language teaching is not about how much you talk—it's about how much your students communicate. TTT ↓ | STT ↑ Learning ↑